Launched in 2018–19, PM-Kisan is the first direct benefit transfer scheme in agriculture. It was launched to protect farmers' incomes in the face of a steep fall in agricultural produce prices since 2016–17. It provides Rs 6000 per annum in three instalments of Rs 2000 each to about 9 crore farmers. The programme has continued despite farm prices recovering in 2019–20. From a political viewpoint, it is quite unlikely that this programme will be withdrawn any time soon. In a manner, it has become an income transfer programme to farmers as it has no linkage to anything other than the beneficiary being registered as a landholder and consequently treated as a farmer.

PM-Kisan has become the largest and the biggest programme of the Ministry of Agriculture. Its outlay exceeds the total outlay of all other schemes of the Department of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare for the year 2020–21.

Agriculture Has Ceased to be the Driver of Global Growth, Employment and Prosperity

From 1.6 billion in 1900, the global population crossed 6 billion in the year 2000. The population of the US went from 76 million in 1900 to over 282 million in 2000. In 1900, the US produced 599.315 million bushels of wheat (16.3 million tonnes); in 2000, it produced 2228.160 million bushels (60.6 million tonnes). The US produced 2661.978 bushels of corn in 1900, which went up to 9915.051 bushels in 2000. In 1900, 41 per cent of the US workforce was employed in agriculture; this fell to just 1.9 per cent in 2000. While agriculture contributed 8 per cent of the US GDP in 1930, it was less than 2 per cent in 2000.

In the twentieth century, the production of wheat and corn increased four times in the US, which was more or less equal to the increase in the population. However, the share of labour force dependent upon agriculture declined from roughly 40 per cent to 1 per cent. The share of agriculture in